by giving political representation to other caste groups that had so far been relatively marginalised.[19] He coined a new acronym for this fresh social coalition: AHINDA. This was a Kannada acronym for 'Alpasankhyataru' (minorities), Hindulidavaru (backward classes) and Dalitaru (Dalits). This is also the caste formulation that Congress Chief Minister Siddaramaiah tried to harness in the 2018 Karnataka assembly poll. Presaging V.P. Singh's 1989 move to change the politics of the Hindi heartland with his adoption of the Mandal Commission report, Urs sought to stir up Karnataka politics with the appointment of the state's first Backward Classes Commission. It was headed by L.G. Havanur, who himself hailed from the backward Beda (hunter) community. This commission identified fifteen backward communities, 128 backward castes and sixty-two backward tribes, and created a new basis for affirmative reservation in the state. The Havanur Commission's findings, as the political scientist Valerian Rodrigues has shown, led to strong protests by upper castes and a challenge in the Karnataka High Court, which upheld its findings. Subsequent Backward Classes Commissions in Karnataka—Venkataswamy Commission (1983–1986) and Justice Chinnappa Reddy Commission (1988–1990)[20]—led to Vokkaligas also being classified as OBCs.[21]

Table 15.1: The Lingayat–Vokkaliga Factor in Karnataka Politics: Chief Ministers and Their Castes (1947–2021)[22]